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The mat on which he slept smelled sweetly of dried grass, and was more softly yielding than the hide of a fresh-killed wild bull.

So, instead of lying there with closed eyes dreaming, why not try to go to sleep again? That would give him the chance to enjoy in full the soft perfection of his "bogbo."

First he would have to revive the fire.

A few dry twigs and a little straw would do. He blew, cheeks puffed, on the smoldering sparks. The smoke sent up its spirals, pungent, suffocating. There was a crackling, the flames burst forth, and warmth invaded the place.

Now, with his back to the fire, he could just fall asleep again stretched out like a boar. He could just bask in the glow like a lizard in the sunshine. All he had to do was imitate the "yassi" with whom he had been living so long.

She set an excellent example. She lay there peacefully, her head resting on a log, naked, her hands on her belly. "Gologolo," she said—snoring, in other words—with her side to a fire that had also burned down to ashes.

What a sound sleep! Sometimes she fumbled at her breasts—wrinkled, flabby breasts like dried tobacco leaves—and scratched herself with long-drawn sighs. Her lips moved. She made gentle little gestures. Then she calmed down again and resumed her even snoring . . .

In a nook behind the fagots, raised above the chickens, ducks and goats, slept Djouma, the sad little yellow dog. He slept curled up, head to tail, on a pile of rubber baskets.

All that was visible of his emaciated body were the ears, standing straight up, pointed, mobile. Every now and then, tickled by a flea or stung by a tick, he would shake them. Occasionally, he would growl without moving any more than Yassiguindja, the favorite yassi of her master, Batouala, the mokoundji. And sometimes, dreaming cynical dreams, he would inveigh against the silence with stifled barks, and open his jaws to snap at the void.

Batouala raised himself and leaned on his elbow. There was no use trying to sleep any more. Everything was in league against him. The mist drizzled in through the entrance to the hut. It was cold. He was hungry. And the day was coming on.

1921

CLAUDE McKAY
1889–1948

Often regarded as the first major poet of the Harlem Renaissance, Claude McKay probably did more than anyone else to shape the trends that would later define that literary movement. More than any other writer of his time, he was able to satisfy and even inspire two major groups of black readers. Many African Americans were attracted to his poetry by its frequently explosive condemnations of bigotry and oppression, written invariably and ironically in such traditional poetic

forms as the sonnet, McKay's favorite. Other readers, more easily moved by poetry in the genteel tradition, were also satisfied, even as they were often introduced at the same time to the power of race-conscious verse. These two groups sometimes seemed irreconcilable. Had it not been for McKay, they might have remained so in the renaissance. He helped uncover some of the unifying principles underlying the major conflicting themes of the writers of the Harlem Renaissance.

Born September 15, 1889, Festus Claudius McKay was the youngest of the eleven children of Thomas and Ann McKay, members of the peasant class in Jamaica. McKay was raised in Sunny Ville, in Clarendon Parish, by a compassionate mother and a stern father who did his best to pass on to his children elements of the customs and traditions of the Ashanti, the West African people from whom he was descended, at least as he understood those customs and traditions. Repeatedly sharing with his children the story of his own father's enslavement by whites, Thomas McKay sought to instill in his offspring a suspicion of whites that would become particularly evident in his son Claude's writing. Other impressions from McKay's childhood that left an indelible mark on his literary productions include his profound respect for the sense of community he encountered among rural Jamaican farmers and a somewhat skeptical attitude toward religion encouraged by his older brother Uriah Theophilus, an elementary-school teacher.

At seventeen, McKay received government sponsorship to become an apprentice to a wheelwright and cabinetmaker in Brown's Town. At nineteen, he moved to Kingston (Jamaica's capital) and served as a police constable for less than a year before his sympathy for the criminals, whom he often considered the victims of an unjust colonial order, led him to return to Clarendon Parish. During the two years that followed, he was encouraged to write poetry in the Jamaican dialect by his most important mentor, Walter Jekyll, an English collector of island folklore with whom McKay had forged a close relationship. In 1912, Jekyll helped him publish two books of dialect poetry: *Songs of Jamaica* (with an introduction by Jekyll and melodies for six selections in an appendix) and *Constab Ballads*. *Songs of Jamaica* is primarily a celebration of the Jamaican peasants, with their relative freedom from bigotry; *Constab Ballads* centers more on Kingston and the contempt and exploitation encountered there by dark-skinned blacks at the hands of whites and mulattos. With their unique melding of traditional verse forms with vivid vernacular speech, the books are now considered foundational texts in the emergence of twentieth-century Caribbean literature. In recognition of their accomplishment, McKay became the first black to receive the medal of the Jamaican Institute of Arts and Sciences, which came with a substantial cash award.

McKay, determined to use the prize money to finance an education at Booker T. Washington's Tuskegee Institute in Alabama, arrived in the United States in 1912, but he departed from Tuskegee in frustration at local conditions two months after his arrival. He went on to study agricultural science for two years at Kansas State College before he decided to resume his career as a writer. He left for Harlem.

Supporting himself at first as a waiter and a porter, McKay familiarized himself with the New York literary scene. He was soon befriended by such important white figures as the famed poet Edwin Arlington Robinson and Waldo Frank, a Jewish radical novelist and cultural critic. His first break came in 1917, when Frank published two of his sonnets, "The Harlem Dancer" and "Invocation," in the December issue of *The Seven Arts*, a highly respected avant-garde magazine. Short story writer Frank Harris, who published several of McKay's poems in *Pearson's*, another magazine, seems also to have made a major impression on the young poet. Unlike later black writers, McKay did not rely primarily on such periodicals as the *Crisis* and *Opportunity* as outlets for his verse. Though he wrote for black magazines on occasion, his most enduring literary ties were with white publications, particularly with the leftist magazines based in Greenwich Village. Indeed, Max Eastman, the dean of the American literary left in the early twentieth century, published McKay's "The Dominant White" in the April 1919 issue of *The Liberator* and nine more of

his poems in the July issue. McKay later served on Eastman's editorial staff, contributing essays and reviews as well as poetry.

In 1919, McKay traveled to England, where he met George Bernard Shaw and worked for a time under Sylvia Pankhurst at *Workers Dreadnought*. C. K. Ogden included nearly two dozen of McKay's poems in the summer 1920 issue of *Cambridge Magazine*; and I. A. Richards, one of the foremost English literary critics of the century, wrote the preface for McKay's third book of verse, *Spring in New Hampshire*. According to Richards, McKay's was among "the best work that the present generation is producing" in Great Britain.

After his return to the United States in 1921, McKay continued to work for and contribute to a number of publications (including his fellow Jamaican Marcus Garvey's *Negro World*, until a political disagreement in 1922 severed their ties). In 1922, he published his most important collection of poetry, *Harlem Shadows*, which, in the opinion of some critics, virtually inaugurated the Harlem Renaissance. According to McKay, the book grew out of his urge to place the militant "If We Must Die," his most famous poem, "inside of a book." The racial violence that racked America in the summer of 1919 had inspired the sonnet, which later served as one of the unofficial rallying cries of the Allied Forces in World War II, particularly after it was recited by Winston Churchill in a speech against the Nazis. Although the poem offers no internal evidence to suggest that it is about race, McKay had refrained from including it in *Spring in New Hampshire* (which was deeply admired by Countee Cullen and Langston Hughes) because of his express desire to avoid racial themes in that book. *Harlem Shadows*, however, marked a point of no return for several members of the literary set in Harlem, who saw in McKay's masterful treatment of racial issues evidence that a black writer's insights into matters of race could serve on more than an occasional basis as suitable subjects for poetry.

In 1923, in Moscow, McKay addressed the Fourth Congress of the Communist International and, as a black poet sympathetic to the Soviet cause (though not an official delegate), achieved instant popularity among most citizens of the U.S.S.R. as well as with Communist Party officials. He was introduced to Trotsky and other leaders, and his poem "Petrograd: May Day, 1923" was published in translation in *Pravda*. McKay also wrote a short book called *Negry v Amerike* (*The Negroes in America*; 1923) that was translated and published by the state publishing firm of the Soviet Union (the original manuscript has been lost, but an English translation of the Russian version was published in 1979). From the Soviet Union, McKay traveled briefly through Germany and then lived several years in France. There he produced his first novel, *Home to Harlem* (1928), and began work on his second, *Banjo* (1929), which he completed during his travels in Spain and Morocco. He eventually settled in Tangier, where he lived from 1930 to 1934.

Home to Harlem was the first novel by a black writer to become a best-seller. Reprinted five times in two months, it seems to have satisfied a consuming curiosity on the part of Americans for information about the nightlife—and the lowlife—of Harlem. The novel examines two characters, both of whom are seen by most critics as existing mainly for the purpose of taking the reader on a tour of Harlem. Jake is a hedonist who deserts the army to return to his beloved Harlem; he falls in love with a prostitute after she affectionately and surreptitiously returns the money he has paid her. Through Jake, the reader is introduced to Ray, a Haitian intellectual who envies Jake because his own desire to become a writer interferes with his enjoyment of life. Predictably, the stern W. E. B. Du Bois had little patience with McKay's presentation of Harlem. Du Bois declared that the book "for the most part nauseates me, and after the dirtier parts of its filth I feel distinctly like taking a bath." McKay's response was simply to accuse Du Bois of failing to make the proper distinction "between the task of propaganda and the work of art."

Banjo continues the story of Ray by matching him with a jovial, restless vagabond and would-be musician named Lincoln Agrippa Daily who is nicknamed "Banjo" after the instrument he plays. The novel did not sell well in the United States, perhaps not only due to the unfortunate timing of its appearance (on the cusp of the

Great Depression) but also as a result of its picaresque form (the book is subtitled "A Story without a Plot") and unfamiliar setting among black dockers and drifters in the Southern French port of Marseille. Nevertheless *Banjo* is one of the most extraordinary novels of the era, both for its cynical analysis of the impact of the grand forces of modernity (above all commerce and colonialism) on individual black lives, and for its almost documentary depiction of interactions among a wide range of characters of African descent from the United States, the Caribbean, and Africa. *Banjo* may also have had the greatest international reach of any novel associated with the renaissance. Translated into French in 1931, it was the single book with the most significant impact on the generation of Caribbean and African students (including Aimé Césaire, Léopold Sédar Senghor, and Léon-Gontran Damas) that would later come to be known as the *Négritude* generation. The French version of the opening of chapter 16, in which Ray argues with a Martinican student about the meaning of a "racial renaissance," was reprinted in one of the founding journals of *Négritude*, the single 1932 issue of *Légitime Défense*, edited by a group of Martinican students including Etienne Léro and René Ménil who found inspiration not only in the work of McKay and Langston Hughes (whom were described as "revolutionary Negro poets") but also in surrealism and communism.

McKay's third novel, *Banana Bottom* (1933), is often regarded as his finest achievement in fiction. *Banana Bottom* tells the story of a Jamaican peasant girl, Bita Plant, who is rescued by the white missionaries Malcolm and Priscilla Craig after being raped. In taking refuge with the Craigs, however, Bita also becomes their prisoner and has their values (including an education in Britain) foisted on her. They even attempt to arrange her marriage. But Bita escapes and, overcoming the memory of rape, returns to the people in her native town of Jubilee. The critical reception of *Banana Bottom* was warm, but sometimes misguided; some reviewers seemed primarily captivated by its descriptions of lush tropical scenery. Like the rest of McKay's prose, except for *Home to Harlem*, *Banana Bottom* did not make much of an impression on the reading public of McKay's time. His collection of short stories, *Gingertown* (1932), did not fare any better.

In 1934, McKay returned to Harlem after twelve years of wandering through Europe and North Africa. He struggled to find employment and even spent a short period in a camp for destitute men before joining the New York branch of the Federal Writers' Project, like many of the most talented black writers of the time (including Dorothy West, Richard Nugent, Roi Ottley, and Ralph Ellison). While on staff there, McKay was able to complete his autobiography, *A Long Way from Home*, which appeared in 1937. He became a regular contributor of articles on race and politics to periodicals such as the *Amsterdam News* and *The New Leader*, and was a central figure in the effort to establish a Negro Writers' Guild (an effort that brought together a number of figures associated with the renaissance, such as Countee Cullen, James Weldon Johnson, and Arthur Schomburg). The last book he was able to publish in his lifetime was a study of black life in New York, *Harlem: Negro Metropolis* (1940), which remains an important historical document, with well-wrought portraits of aspects of Harlem life in the 1930s (including the "numbers" racket and the religious leader Father Divine). Through Ellen Tarry, a friend who wrote children's books, McKay became involved in the activities of Friendship House, a Catholic-sponsored community center in Harlem. Tarry's influence on McKay culminated in his conversion to Roman Catholicism in 1944, after he had moved to Chicago, where he spent the remainder of his life teaching classes at the Catholic Youth Organization. Despite serious health problems after 1941, he continued to write poetry and completed at least one unpublished book-length fiction manuscript, *Amiable with Big Teeth*, which concerned efforts among black political leaders in Harlem to organize support for Ethiopia after it had been invaded by Mussolini's Italy in the fall of 1935.

When McKay died in 1948, the world lost someone who, according to William Stanley Braithwaite, had once promised to be "the keystone of the new movement in racial poetic achievement." Unlike Countee Cullen, the other great figure of the

Harlem Renaissance who treated racial themes in conventional poetic forms, Claude McKay was not at all concerned with living up to the intellectual, political, or social expectations of Du Bois or Alain Locke. In fact, he once referred to Locke's anthology, *The New Negro*, as a "remarkable chocolate soufflé of art and politics." Concerned with political consequences, McKay was a worker for social change; and subtle though his poetry indisputably is on some levels, he believed strongly that too many black poets had hidden behind lofty standards of poetic refinement to keep from offending white readers. He refused to mask his impatience with racism in this way. He managed to use traditional poetic forms as satisfying vehicles for the expression of that impatience; but at the same time, McKay refused to allow social relevance to become an excuse for the production of inferior art. McKay was a courageous thinker and writer who prized his intimate knowledge of all classes of people. His work rings with an authority and authenticity matched by that of few of his contemporaries.

The Harlem Dancer

Applauding youths laughed with young prostitutes
And watched her perfect, half-clothed body sway;
Her voice was like the sound of blended flutes
Blown by black players upon a picnic day.
She sang and danced on gracefully and calm, 5
The light gauze hanging loose about her form;
To me she seemed a proudly-swaying palm
Grown lovelier for passing through a storm.
Upon her swarthy neck black shiny curls
Luxuriant fell; and tossing coins in praise, 10
The wine-flushed, bold-eyed boys, and even the girls,
Devoured her shape with eager, passionate gaze;
But looking at her falsely-smiling face,
I knew her self was not in that strange place.

1917

Harlem Shadows

I hear the halting footsteps of a lass
  In Negro Harlem when the night lets fall
Its veil. I see the shapes of girls who pass
  To bend and barter at desire's call.
Ah, little dark girls who in slippered feet 5
Go prowling through the night from street to street!

Through the long night until the silver break
  Of day the little gray feet know no rest;
Through the lone night until the last snow-flake
  Has dropped from heaven upon the earth's white breast, 10
The dusky, half-clad girls of tired feet
Are trudging, thinly shod, from street to street.

Ah, stern harsh world, that in the wretched way
  Of poverty, dishonor and disgrace,
Has pushed the timid little feet of clay,
  The sacred brown feet of my fallen race!
Ah, heart of me, the weary, weary feet
In Harlem wandering from street to street.

1918

If We Must Die[1]

If we must die, let it not be like hogs
Hunted and penned in an inglorious spot,
While round us bark the mad and hungry dogs,
Making their mock at our accursed lot.
If we must die, O let us nobly die,
So that our precious blood may not be shed
In vain; then even the monsters we defy
Shall be constrained to honor us though dead!
O kinsmen! we must meet the common foe!
Though far outnumbered let us show us brave,
And for their thousand blows deal one deathblow!
What though before us lies the open grave?
Like men we'll face the murderous, cowardly pack,
Pressed to the wall, dying, but fighting back!

1919

To the White Fiends

Think you I am not fiend and savage too?
Think you I could not arm me with a gun
And shoot down ten of you for every one
Of my black brothers murdered, burnt by you?
Be not deceived, for every deed you do
I could match—out-match: am I not Afric's son,
Black of that black land where black deeds are done?
But the Almighty from the darkness drew
My soul and said: Even thou shalt be a light
Awhile to burn on the benighted earth,
Thy dusky face I set among the white
For thee to prove thyself of higher worth;
Before the world is swallowed up in night,
To show thy little lamp: go forth, go forth!

1919

1. Written following the "Red Summer" of 1919, when antiblack riots broke out in several cities, notably Chicago. McKay later denied that the poem referred to blacks and whites specifically.